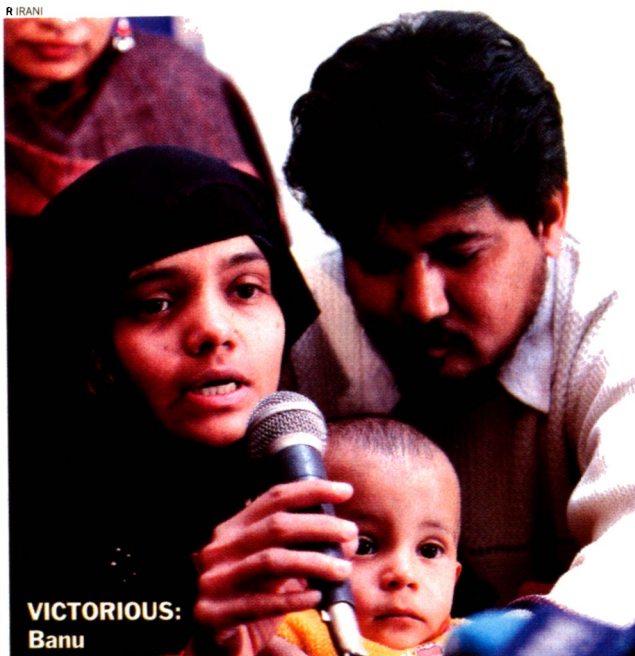


Delayed But Not Denied

AHMEDABAD Justice delayed is not always justice denied. That's what came home last week, six years after the gruesome Gujarat riots of 2002 that broke out after a train full of Ramsevaks was allegedly set on fire by a Muslim mob at the Godhra railway station.

In the ensuing aftermath, three men had raped a pregnant Bilkis Banu while a mob massacred 17 Muslims including Banu's small daughter and relatives as they were fleeing their village near Godhra to escape the Hindu fury. A Mumbai sessions court has sentenced 11 of the accused to life imprisonment in the sensational rape and massacre case.

Constable Soma Gori has been sentenced to three years' imprisonment while five other policemen and two government doctors—who were charged with tampering evidence—have been let off. The Gujarat Government



VICTORIOUS:
Banu

had handed over the case to CBI in 2003 at the behest of the Supreme Court, which had transferred the trial to Mumbai following representations by human rights activists that a free and fair trial was not possible in the state.

The judgement brings the curtain down on one of the most gruesome cases of the 2002 riots. "Government personnel too should have been convicted. I will fight to bring them to book," said an elated Banu. CBI offi-

cers congratulated her on her courage that paved the way for the success of the case. The verdict has come as a victory for human rights activists who have been fighting for justice for Muslims victims of the Gujarat riots. But their role is under question on the grounds that they have launched an undercover operation to defend those who were responsible for the killing of Ramsevaks at Godhra, to ensure their acquittal.

by Uday Mahurkar

SIGNPOSTS

LAUNCHED Israeli satellite **Polaris** by ISRO's indigenous Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV). This is the second time that a core alone PSLV configuration has put a foreign satellite into orbit.

APPOINTED Ashish N. Soni, as the president of the



Fashion Design Council of India (FDCI). He succeeds Ritu Kumar.

WON By shooters **P. T. Raghunath, Samaresh Jung, Heena Sidhu** and **Suma Shirur**, gold medals at the Hungarian Open shooting championships in the air rifle and air pistol categories.

DIED Congress leader and Thane district Congress committee vice-president **Pawan Kumar Pandey**, 55. He was also a leader of the Uttar Bharatiya Sangh.

DIED **Amar Singh Kotha**, 72, five-time BJP legislator from Sarangpur in Rajgarh district of Madhya Pradesh.

VIS-A-VIS **PRAKASH KARAT** CPI(M) general secretary **versus** **RAVI SHANKAR PRASAD** BJP spokesperson

“We have a communal party like BJP and a party of capitalists like the Congress. We need a third alternative.”



“Since Independence, Indian politics has become bi-polar, which CPI(M) and the Left Front have failed to either note or appreciate.”

EPILOGUE: Far from being bi-polar, politics is multi-polar now with coalitions ruling the roost everywhere.